

BEFORE A STORM W. Bengal Governor C.V. Ananda Bose with Mamata Banerjee at a convocation ceremony, Feb. 6

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WEST BENGAL

NEW GOVERNOR, NEW ROWS

By Romita Datta

A stormy three years it had been, from August 2019 to July 2022, when Jagdeep Dhankhar, now India's vice-president, served as governor of West Bengal. Scarcely a week passed without Raj Bhavan and the Trinamool Congress government sniping at each other. Dhankhar said his frequent travels in the state to assess the ground situation and critical statements thereafter were but a fulfilment of his constitutional duty; the TMC government accused him of gross interference. Thus, when a new governor took over in November 2022, there was expectation that ties would improve with Raj Bhavan. Indeed, things went swimmingly well at first with the soft-spoken C.V. Ananda Bose. A retired IAS officer who joined the BJP in 2019, Bose seemed to enjoy genuine warmth with chief minister Mamata Banerjee. "The governor is so nice...I think there won't be any more problems," Mamata had said at Bose's *haate khori* ceremony of learning the Bengali alphabet at Saraswati Puja on January 26. Bose, too, was effusive in praising Mamata. The state BJP, used to dropping in on Dhankhar frequently to post allegations against the TMC, was taken aback at the thickening bonhomie. They need not have worried.

Political watchers saw a change in Bose after his two visits to New Delhi—on January 28, when he met Union home minister Amit Shah, and another on February 13, when he had a meeting with his predecessor Dhankhar. Even before the second visit, Bose had issued an order that his principal secretary, Nandini Chakravorty, be changed. The charge was that she was misinforming the government about activities at Raj Bhavan. "As long as the governor maintains an air of courtesy, there will be courtesy on our part," the state government had said testily then. It was a presage of worse to come.

AFTER BOSE SLAMMED THE ATTACK ON PRAMANIK, THE TMC LIKENED HIM TO DHANKHAR

After returning to Kolkata, Bose took to dashing off press releases airing his opinion on the current situation in Bengal. For example, after a discussion over political violence in Bengal with state BJP president Sukanta Mazumdar at Raj Bhavan, Bose wrote: "Be you ever so high, the law is always above you." Most observers took it, rightly, as veiled criticism of the ruling dispensation.

The ties between Bose and the TMC government reached a nadir after Raj Bhavan issued a statement on February 27 asking the state to take strict action against those who attacked Union minister of state Nisith Pramanik's convoy in Coochbehar district two days before. The governor will check "the rot in the root", it said. Within a day, TMC mouthpiece *Jago Bangla* struck back, with its editorial saying that "the present governor has entered the race to follow in the footsteps of the former governor".